

by the poet himself. Here it will be difficult for a reader who is genuinely using the book as an introductory text to recognize how greatly H.'s view differs from the *communis opinio*.

H.'s shift away from a biographical approach is strongly felt in his discussion of love elegy's social background. One recognizes the influence of contemporary scholarship on H.'s description of both the *poeta/amator* and the *puella* as poetic constructs whose models are not to be sought in individual historic personalities but whose construction does meaningfully reflect significant aspects of Roman political, social, and sexual life. H. speaks of an elegiac *Gegenwelt* created by the poets without, however, reducing the concept to simple 'anti-Augustanism'. While the cases of Gallus and Ovid are used to frame a discussion of the elegists' relations to the Princes, H. astutely notes how little we know definitively about our central elegists, Propertius and Tibullus, in this regard.

Chs 2–5 are devoted to each of the four elegists, respectively. While H. is surely right to emphasize the importance of Virgil's tenth *Eclogue* for our knowledge of Gallus, he devotes too much attention to questioning the authenticity of the Qasr Ibrim papyrus without offering new arguments. In any case, the text should have been included for readers to examine for themselves. H. proceeds through the collections of Propertius, Tibullus, and Ovid book by book, poem by poem. This method, which H. sees as mirroring the practice of ancient readers using their book-rolls, does indeed provide the reader with a sense that he is progressively engaged with the different facets of the elegiac experience as it unfolds. This is especially effective with Tibullus, who often introduces surprising developments or changes in consecutive poems. Unfortunately, the advantages of this approach are compromised by H.'s determination to impose precise structural patterns both on individual books and on collections. This is particularly problematic with Propertius, where H. insists, for example, on treating elegies 3.1–3.3, 3.4–3.5, and 3.24–25 as single poems in order to produce a scheme of 1 + 20 poems to match his similarly contrived schemes for the remaining books.

H.'s inclusion of the Pseudo-Tibullan Book 3 is commendable, even if much of what he argues is (necessarily) controversial. The presentation and discussion of the Sulpicia epigrams is set up well by the depiction of epigram as elegy's 'little sister' in ch. 1 (10). Ch. 5, on Ovid, again includes some odd structural assertions, but there is also a lively discussion of Ovid's humour and a fine treatment of the poet's insistence on taking an elegiac motif such as *militia amoris* 'beim Wort' (118).

There is much of value for scholars and students in this intelligent book, and I would recommend it to both, though with a caveat: throughout the book, H. forcefully argues his own opinions, especially when they differ from commonly accepted views. This aspect makes it an interesting and provocative read for scholars, but it might prove difficult for the uninitiated to recognize to what (sometimes great) extent H.'s views are primarily his own. Aside from several printing errors in the poem numbers of Propertius (e.g. 2.20.1 for 2.2.1, p. 53), the book is well edited.

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JERI BLAIR DEBROHUN

M. SKOIE, *READING SULPICIA. COMMENTARIES 1475–1990*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002. Pp. 362. ISBN 0-19-924573-8. £50.00.

The small collection of fragmented poems now generally attributed to Augustan elegist Sulpicia has a complex and colourful hermeneutic history, as Mathilde Skoie elegantly illustrates in her first book. Questions of authenticity and authorship, aesthetic and literary status, issues of philology and biography, gender and morality have been debated since antiquity in relation to the so-called *Appendix Tibulliana* and remain central concerns in the reading and reception of a text now credited with special significance as composed by one of classical literature's few extant female authors.

Chronologically organized across six chapters, framed by an introduction and conclusion, S.'s study traces the reception of the Sulpicia poems of the *Corpus Tibullianum* from antiquity through the Renaissance and up to the end of the last century. In an impressive display of scholarship, the book offers detailed analysis of seven key readings of the Sulpicia poems in commentaries by Cyllenius (1475), Scaliger (1577), Heyne (1755), Dissen (1835), Gruppe (1838), Smith (1913), and Tränkle (1990), mapping the vagaries of fashion and philology that inform each work. Deftly balancing her own readings of the commentaries alongside their historical readings of Sulpicia, S. makes effective use of some of the literary critical tools offered by contemporary feminist and reception theory to describe, not so much a hermeneutic tradition of reading Sulpicia, but of reading *Sulpiciae* — including a fifteenth-century '*Sulpicia togata*', a sixteenth-century '*Sulpicia puella*', an eighteenth-century 'authentic' Augustan Sulpicia, a nineteenth-century 'amateur' Sulpicia, and among a variety of twentieth-century *Sulpiciae*, a '*Sulpicia Americana*' and a '*Sulpicia philologica*'. Her Gadamerian conclusion — 'Quot commentatores, tot Sulpiciae' (308) — seems well founded, indeed.

Appendices include the Postgate text (1915) and translation (1912) of the Sulpicia poems (*Corpus Tibullianum* 3.13–18) with a checklist of the different numbering conventions followed by various commentators, and a chronologically ordered selection of plates reproducing samples from these commentaries. The full bibliography, also chronologically ordered, distinguishes works on Sulpician scholarship (including works of criticism and a register of editions, commentaries, and translations) from other works cited, illustrating the range of reading covered in this survey — as well as the burgeoning interest in matters Sulpician among classical scholars during the 1990s.

While this new work should serve to enhance and inform that interest, it may strike some readers as regrettable that the book offers no direct reading of the poems by S. herself. Throughout the book, a sustained and profitable focus upon issues of gender and sexual morality offers evidence of the active presence of the twenty-first-century voice of S. in this dialogic exchange between text(s), commentator(s), and critic(s), but this discerning reader resists the temptation to offer a new, twenty-first-century reading of Sulpicia. Instead, she offers an accessible and incisive case-study in the hermeneutics of reading and reception, and as an erudite analysis of the gendered dynamics of reading one of classical literature's most challenging authors her book offers a valuable new contribution to the field.

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GENEVIEVE LIVELEY

P. HARDIE, *OID'S POETICS OF ILLUSION*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002. Pp. viii + 365. ISBN 0-521800-87-0. £45.00.

Ovid's presence at the centre of the Latin canon must now be beyond doubt. A suppler understanding of allusion, a post-modern interest in the phenomenon of textuality, and the revival of psychoanalytic criticism have all replaced the puerile genre wrecker who single-handedly brought down the Augustan golden age with a poet uniquely responsive to contemporary literary sensibilities. This re-location of Ovid from the end of the classical tradition to the beginning of our own receives its most comprehensive and stimulating confirmation in Philip Hardie's ambitious new book. H. reveals the dynamic of absent presences as a defining poetic interest throughout Ovid's career. From the *Amores* to the exile poetry, Ovid simultaneously celebrates the text's capacity to project the figures it describes, and the author who produces it, into the immediate experience of its readers and exposes these presences as mere illusions that mark above all the distance between representation and reality. This focus yields a new and strikingly coherent overview of the entire corpus (or virtually, since there is no sustained discussion of the didactic works), with the *Amores* very much at its 'heart', and fires a broader argument about literary history. For H. wants not just to make the now common point about post-modern critical concerns unlocking Ovid's texts. Rather he suggests that Ovid above all stands at the head of a tradition of exploring the limits of illusionism from antiquity to the present. Hence the readings of post-Classical re-workings of Ovid, from Petrarch through the English Renaissance to the classicizing French painter Gérôme, that at once provide some pre-modern perspectives on Ovid's work and show the consistency with which Ovidian scenes have drawn visual and verbal artists to contemplate the powers of their craft.

The introductory chapter gives a panorama of literary, philosophical, and political contexts for Ovid's 'thematization of a dialectic of absence and presence', linking it to Homer's seeing Muses, rhetorical interest in vivid visualization, philosophical — particularly Lucretian — theories of the senses, Augustus' construction of himself as a 'present god', and, least expectedly but most fruitfully, pastoral fantasies of an animate countryside full of substantial echoes of its inhabitants' desires. Desire too is the subject of the second chapter, which, via Freudian and Lacanian arguments, proposes that the *Amores*' overt fictionality translates erotic longing into a quest for a real presence on the part of the reader and conversely shows how the lover experiences his *puella* as a text. Ch. 3 makes the transition from the *Amores* to the *Metamorphoses* by way of the song of Orpheus in Book 10: for the lover, now separated from his beloved by death, the quest for presence becomes an impulse to construct an artistic monument embodying the lost, a move that leads H. to a rich discussion of the memorial functions of the poem as a whole. The next chapter turns to the *Heroides*, where the final paired epistles strive to overcome the letter's essential inadequacy as a substitute for bodily reality. An important 'digression' here sketches an opposition between elegy, as a genre founded on absence, and pastoral fictions of poetic presence that, H. shows, informs Ovid's discourse in the *Metamorphoses* as well. Narcissus in ch. 5 as the figure of the reader separated from what he longs for by the invisible barrier between illusion and reality leads to a treatment of ecphrasis as an analogue for metamorphosis and for the texts/images that it produces and to the figure of Pygmalion, 'a central symbol not only in the western myth of the artist, but also in fantasies of the fulfilment of desire'. Ch. 7 turns to another medium of re-presentation, rhetorical figures embedded in the poetry's linguistic surface like syllepsis, personification, and metaphor that 'creat[e] and commen[t] on illusions of presence'. The next chapter, both a conclusion of what has